increased with each passing day and I even started having problems with my right elbow.

I was in Baroda when I got to know that my surgeon, Dr Andrew Wallace, was in Delhi for a day. However, with no flight connections to Delhi from where I was, I was beginning to get worried about how to get to him before he left. That's when my good friend Amit Bhatia stepped in. Amit, who is an ardent cricket fan, gave me a ride in his private jet and made sure I reached Dr Wallace in good time. On examining my shoulder, Dr Wallace said that during rehabilitation athletes often put too much load on the non-injured limbs to compensate and it was likely that's what had happened to me. He asked me to have a few scans, to figure out the nature of the problem. I did not want to fuel more speculation in the media about my injury, so when I went to get the scans done, I resorted to wearing a burkha, which shows how difficult things were at the time! John Gloster, our new physio, accompanied me to the hospital and the scans revealed a small cyst next to a nerve. I was told I needed to get it removed as soon as possible, though I could play on for the moment.

My return to international cricket finally happened on 25 October 2005 in the first ODI of a series against Sri Lanka. It was a truly emotional moment when I took the field after six months out and the first thing I did was to look up to the heavens and thank God for giving me another opportunity. I scored 93 and this time it was exactly the sort of comeback I had hoped for. My first scoring shot was a cover drive for four against the medium-pacer Farveez Maharoof and I flicked the next ball to square leg for another boundary. I was determined to make the most of this lifeline. We won the match by 152 runs and went on to take the series 6–1.

In the three-Test series that followed in December 2005 I scored my thirty-fifth Test century, making the world record my own. The hundred had eluded me for a while and at Chennai, the venue for the first Test, I was beginning to wonder how long I would have to wait. Though most of the drawn Chennai Test was lost to rain, something happened there that put me in good spirits: I had a dream in which I saw myself scoring the thirty-fifth hundred in Delhi, the venue of the second Test.

I didn't really expect it to work out that way, of course, but then towards the end of 10 December, the very first day of the Delhi Test, I found myself in the nineties as the light began to fade rapidly. The